The Family Meeting Before the Decision

How to hear your loved one, hear each other and write down where you stand.

The family is getting together to talk about what happens next. Each relative is arriving with an answer already in mind. Your loved one has a view too, and it may not have been said out loud in front of everyone yet.

This guide is for one meeting with one job: get your loved one's wishes, each relative's view and the open questions onto one page. It isn't for choosing anything.

Who should be there

Your loved one, first. Then everyone who is or will be part of their care: the sibling who lives ten minutes away, the one who phones every night from another state, the neighbor or friend who already helps. A relative who can't come can send their answers ahead. [1]

If your loved one can't be in the room, ask them beforehand and bring what they said, in their words.

Ask one person to keep the notes and a different person to guide the conversation.

How to open

Start with your loved one's words, not with anyone's proposal. If they're in the room, ask them. If they aren't, read aloud what they told you. The Family Caregiver Alliance describes a successful family meeting as one that gives everyone a chance to be heard. [1]

- “Before we talk about what to do, I'd like us to hear what matters to you.”
- “Nobody has to agree with anybody today. We're here to get everyone's view onto one page.”
- Say what the meeting is for: hearing each person and writing down where the family stands. Say what it isn't for: picking an option.

Questions to ask

Ask your loved one

1. What matters most to you in what happens next?

2. What do you want to stay the same, whatever we decide?

3. What worries you about it?

Ask each other

Go around the room. Each person answers each question, and a short answer gets the same attention as a long one.

1. What are you most worried about?

2. What outcome are you hoping for?

3. What can you realistically do yourself, and what can't you?

4. Where do we already agree, and where do we want different things?

5. What do we still need to find out before we decide, and who can tell us?

How to write down what was said

Keep your loved one's words apart from the family's. Where two relatives see it differently, write both views in words each would call fair, and don't settle it. The page is finished when everyone is on it, not when everyone agrees.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT	WHO SEES IT DIFFERENTLY	STILL TO FIND OUT
“I want to stay where I can see my garden.”	Your loved one		
Most worried about the hours when nobody else is in the house.	Denise	Marcus sees this differently	A question for the doctor or the nurse

What not to decide yet

These come later, and some of them need the people who assess your loved one. Today's page is what they'll start from. Leave them open.

- Which option to choose.
- Who is right.

- Whether your loved one is safe as things are.
- What the choice should finally rest on.

What you can decide today

- Who will write up the page and send it to everyone, so each person can check that their own line is fair.
- Who will take each open question to the person who can answer it: your loved one, the doctor, the nurse or a care consultant.
- When you'll talk again.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't settle a disagreement, choose for you, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets the family onto one page, with your loved one's words at the top and the differences left on it.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one page now, with your loved one's words at the top and the differences still on it. The care interview sets that page beside a full account of their situation, area by area, and turns it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting